

145-YEARS OF RAIL IN PETERBOROUGH



The government purchased 30 acres of land from Mr Koch in July 1880 which was known as the Railway Reserve.

The railway line from Port Pirie via Jamestown was completed on 14th December 1880.

The line was officially opened on 17th January 1881 by the Governor of South Australia, Sir William Jervois although the line from Terowie had not been completed and our history as a 'Railway Town' began. The line from Terowie to Petersburg was opened on 11th May 1881.

A stone railway station and goods shed were built. The station was built on the south side of the railway line although the town's residents lobbied for it to be built on the north side.

The post office and Institute were built in 1882 in the Railway Reserve on the north side of the railway line.

The narrow guage railway line from Petersburg reached Orroroo in September 1881 and was extended to Quorn to meet the Port August line in May 1882.

The standard guage line to the NSW border was completed in June 1887 and to Broken Hill via Silverton in November 1887. The line to Cockburn was funded by the SA Government and the continuation to Broken Hill was built by private investors from NSW.

The beginning of the railways in Petersburg caused a housing problem with the influx of workers.

A cottage was built in 1881 on the corner of Main Street and Mill Street for the engineer and an office was built in the back yard. The engineer's workshop was opposite the house on the south side of the railway line.



*Engineer's Cottage – Main Street - 1892
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection*

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Three private boarding houses were built in 1881 and work by the masons and carpenters was done by lamp light to get them finished as the need for housing was so great.

There were three workmen's cottages and the Loco foreman's house built in 1883 east of the railway station facing Railway Terrace. Another house was built west of the railway station in the railway yards.



*Cottages in Railway yards
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection*



*Snow at the Railway Station – 1895 - old running shed
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection*

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Mr Stanislaus Malycha was reportedly the first person to build a house for rent. This house (possibly in Railway Terrace) was near the original iron Methodist Church (which was sold to the Catholic Church in 1884) built between the Broken Hill and Terowie Railway Lines opposite the present Catholic Church. Mr Malycha built over one hundred houses in Petersburg.

Land was purchased west of the railway reserve from Richard Cochrane in December 1887 for the construction of new loco sheds. Tenders were called for the removal of the running shed and construction of a new carriage shed, followed by loco shops and two permanent way-men's cottages.



*Waymen's Cottage in Railway yards
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection*



*Petersburg Loco Depot – c 1907
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection*

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In 1890 Mr Cochrane offered 130 quarter acre allotments for sale on the south side of the railway line and to the west of Mr Koch's allotments which was known as the recreation ground. 78 houses were built and with 305 residents, most of these being railway men. This area was bordered by Railway Terrace and Hill Street and by West Terrace and Ellen Street. At the time the land was still under the control of the District Council of Yongala and was known as Cochrane's Town. This was included in the Corporation of Petersburg as Yongala Ward in 1897.

By 1891, Petersburg was the busiest railway station outside of Adelaide with sometimes over 75 trains per day passing through the station. The government was about to build workshops, and 40 men and their families would come from Port Pirie to work in them.

There was already an acute housing shortage with rents high. Many established families were living in the most primitive of structures while waiting for houses to be built. Small houses were being built but most were already rented out before they were built. Most railway employees were living in tents, and they could not bring their families with them. Some families were living in boarding houses often crowded into one or two rooms.

Houses were built in the Railway yards for the works managers. The Superintendent's house was built out of sandstone in 1891. A lecture room was built adjoining the house.

In 1895 two more houses were built near the superintendent's house in Railway Terrace. The Loco Superintendent and Works Foreman houses were built in 1895 with their front yards facing the railway line.



*Loco Superintendent and Works Foreman houses - 1971
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection*

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In 1898 The council purchased seven feet of Mr Koch's road West Terrace to make their new road Hurlstone Street a legal width. The remnants of West Terrace is now the wide footpath along Hurlstone Street between Moscow Street and Railway Terrace.

In 1899 the railways had 21 cottages for their workers all in the railway reserve. This included houses obtained for their workers in Main Street (three where Rotary Park is now) and Railway Terrace west of Hurlstone Street.

There were eight cottages in the yards along Railway Terrace between Hurlstone Street and Mill Street, the engineer's house in Main Street plus the two way-men's cottages.

The Subway was opened on Monday 12th November. The Subway which ran from the Railway Station to the Main Street, took four months to be constructed after the townspeople lobbied for many years to have an overpass or subway built.



*Petersburg Subway
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection*

By 1901 there were over 300 men employed in the railways at Petersburg and little to no housing for the workers.

New loco stores were built in 1911 although there were concerns that they would be unsuitable with no airflow for workers.

In 1912 the cattle and sheep yards were removed from Mill Street, and two semi-detached reinforced concrete cottages were built for single men at a cost of £508.

There is also a semi-detached cottage in Kitchener Street which is very similar to the other railway cottages which may have been built at the same time.

The Railway Commissioner secured 10 acres of land from the corporation to build houses. This land was originally purchased by the corporation for the intention of building a public slaughter house.

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Twenty-six houses were proposed and sixteen of these were to be procceed with at once.

These Semi-detached four roomed cottages were built to the west of the town in Cyanide Avenue near the Gold Battery and Cyanide works in 1912.

Only 18 (9 double cottages) of these semi-detached cottages were built and in 1917 the railways lobbied to have the street name changed from Cyanide Avenue to Tripney Avenue.

The semi-detached cottages in Mill Street along with one of the way-man's cottages were demolished around 1967 and the semi-detached cottages in Tripney Avenue were demolished in 1973. The remaining way-man's cottage in Railway Terrace was still standing in 1988 but has since been demolished.

Cottage number	Street	Occupation	Cottage number	Street	Occupation
	MILL STREET			TRIPNEY AVENUE	
1	HATELEY Eileen Alice May	Married	9	LESCHKE Johann Frederick	Carpenter
	HATELEY Walter Cyril	Electrical Fitter		LESCHKE Mavel	Home Duties
2	REID Gertrude	Married	10	NEWTON Austin	Labourer
	REID Jack	Clerk		NEWTON Catherine Elizabeth	Married
	GRAHAM Caroline Viola	Tailoress	11	HODGSON James Arthur	Engineman
	TRIPNEY AVENUE			LESCHKE Frederick Raymond	Labourer
1	HODGSON Cara Annie	Home Duties	12	COFFEY John Joseph	Storeman
	TAYLOR Annie Laura	Home Duties		COFFEY Margaret Jane	Married
	TAYLOR William John	Rly Guard	13	BROWN William Stewart	Machinist
2	GRICE Martha Agnes	Home Duties		RODGERS Alfred Claude	Fireman
	GRICE Reginald	Chargemans Mate		RODGERS Fanny	Home Duties
3	HENNESSY Alice Lydia Maud	Home Duties	14	KELLY Mary Ellen	Married
	HENNESSY Maurice Michael	Cleaner		KELLY William	SAR Porter
4	TRIPNEY Harry Montague	Fireman	15	SALVANO Catherine Mary	Home Duties
	TRIPNEY Mary	Married		SALVANO Louis Antony	SAR Guard
5	SAMPSON Alice Bessie Muriel	Home Duties	16	GUTHRIE Alice Maud	Home Duties
	SAMPSON Victor Lavender	Guard		GUTHRIE Matthew Michael	Ass Train Cont
6	WOOD Florence Winifred	Home Duties	17	GRAY Rowland Harold	Drapers Ass
	WOOD Harold Burnaby	SAR Fireman		MORGAN Cecilia Govenia	Home Duties
7	BROWN Kathleen Annie	Shop Assistant		MORGAN George	Engine Driver
	BROWN Thomas John	Fitter	19	MARCH Athenica	Home Duties
8	CHERRY Alice	Home Duties		MARCH Walter Bert	Labourer
	CHERRY Walter James Henry	Carrier	20	TAYLOR Grace Lawson	Shop Ass
	GUTHRIE Alice Mary	Home duties			



Railway cottages in Mill Street
Lionel Noble Collection



*Railway cottages in Tripney Avenue
Lionel Noble Collection*



*Railway cottages in Tripney Avenue
Lionel Noble Collection*



*Railway cottages in Tripney Avenue being demolished
Lionel Noble Collection*



*Petersburg Railway Station – 1890s
Lionel Noble Collection*



*Petersburg Railway Station - 1890
Lionel Noble Collection*



Newspaper stand, Refreshment Rooms and Railway Station - Petersburg - c1910
Lionel Noble Collection



Petersburg Loco Sheds – 1910s
Lionel Noble Collection



*Peterborough Railway Station – 1920s
Lionel Noble Collection*



*Petersburg Loco Sheds – 1920s
Lionel Noble Collection*

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The railway yards were extensively remodelled in 1925-1926 with new Loco depot and a roundhouse constructed. Barracks and a dining hall for the workers were built near the Quorn crossing.



*Peterborough Roundhouse - 1969
Lionel Noble Collection*

It was announced in 1962 that the Port Pirie to Cockburn line would be standardised from the 3ft 6in narrow gauge to the new 4ft 8 ½ in standard gauge. The line between Terowie and Peterborough was to be converted to the broad gauge of 5ft 3in. The first diesel locomotive arrived at Peterborough on 6 February 1963. By June 1964 construction had started on the standard gauge line and bridges and culverts between Manna Hill and Cockburn were beginning to take form.

With the standardization of the railways a new administration building, railway station, platform, refreshment room and goods shed were built to replace the earlier buildings, as well as new diesel maintenance shop, rolling stock repair shop, staff amenities building, yardmasters office, bogie exchange depot and transfer platforms.

The standard railway line between Port Pirie and Broken Hill was opened on 16th January 1970 and the inaugural service of the Indian Pacific passenger train between Perth and Sydney ran on 24th February.

The amalgamation of the State (S.A.R.) and Commonwealth Railways (A.N.) took place on 1 March 1978 and the Peterborough division was now under control of central region until 13th November when it became part of the northern region with headquarters in Port Augusta. At this time there were 489 employees in Peterborough. This amalgamation was the beginning of the end for railway operations in Peterborough.

By 1980 the last goods trains operated from Quorn to Peterborough, and the last narrow gauge Ghan Rail Service ran on 24th November. By this time stations were closed at Terowie and Wirrabara, with Orroroo station closing on 31 July 1981. In the following three years stations at Laura, Melrose, Booleroo Centre, Wilmington and Yunta were all closed. Crystal Brook and Jamestown was closed in 1986/87.

The Adelaide/Crystal Brook standard gauge line was opened late in 1982 and the building of a new bogie exchange at Dry Creek signalled the demise of Peterborough as a railway town. Bluebird passenger services to Adelaide ceased to operate on 13 December 1986 and the railway station was closed in 1995. The only passenger service to now pass through Peterborough is the Indian Pacific although it no longer stops.

There were only 147 employees working in the Peterborough railway yards in 1988: 25 in the loco shop, 9 works foreman, 3 in the stores, 4 plant depot, 15 permanent way and 91 in operations.



*Peterborough Railway Station - 1969
Lionel Noble Collection*



*Peterborough Loco Sheds – 1970
Lionel Noble Collection*

Australian Rail cut twenty-one jobs at Peterborough in June 1991 which left the number of technical and maintenance staff as nine.

The last remaining National Rail workers finished in July 1997. The six workers were employed on track maintenance and were the last of a gradual decline in numbers since 1978, ended over 117 years of railway employment in the town.